ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Ellipsis and substitution

Advanced cohesion often depends on what speakers choose not to repeat. Ellipsis leaves a grammatical gap; substitution installs a compact form that points back to an earlier expression.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Reduce repetition while keeping the missing or substituted meaning fully recoverable.

Remove recoverable material or replace it with one, ones, do so, so and not while preserving reference, contrast and register.

MODEL

I ordered the red one; Maya did too.

recoverable structure -> omission | repeated constituent -> substitute form

6 GUIDED STAGES · 29 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Distinguish ellipsis from substitution.

OUTCOME 2

02

Recover omitted material without losing reference.

OUTCOME 3

03

Choose natural devices for conversation, formal prose and comparison.

Build meaning before form

Remove recoverable material or replace it with one, ones, do so, so and not while preserving reference, contrast and register.

Ellipsis and substitution are different operations

In Maya can sing and Leo can too, the repeated verb phrase is omitted after can: this is ellipsis. In I need a pen; do you have one?, one replaces the noun phrase: this is substitution.

Both create cohesion, but they obey different structural restrictions.

Recoverability is the central test

A listener must be able to reconstruct the intended material from the grammar and discourse. If two possible antecedents compete, the shorter version becomes ambiguous rather than elegant.

Parallel structure, agreement and contrast all help the reader recover what is absent.

Question	Check
What is missing?	identify the repeated constituent
Where is its antecedent?	locate the recoverable source
Could another reading fit?	remove ambiguity

Choosing among one, do so and so

One and ones substitute for count noun phrases. Do so replaces a verb phrase, especially in planned or formal prose. So and not substitute for whole propositions after verbs such as think, hope, suppose and expect.

Lexical choice and register matter: She said she would and She undertook to do so are both cohesive, but they belong to different contexts.

Natural economy, not mechanical deletion

Not every repetition is a flaw. Repeating a key noun can protect clarity across a long paragraph, and full wording can carry emphasis that ellipsis would remove.

Use economy where the relationship remains immediate and unmistakable.

Reason through the pattern

The bridge connects an antecedent to either a licensed gap or a substitute. The learner checks reference first, then selects the grammatical device.

01	02	03	04
recoverable structure	omission	repeated constituent	substitute form

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify exactly which words are repeated.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Check that the antecedent is unambiguous.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Choose ellipsis when the grammar licences an empty position.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Choose one, do so, so or not when an explicit substitute improves cohesion.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Device	Target	Example
one/ones	count noun phrase	the red one
do so	verb phrase/event	They agreed to do so.
so/not	proposition	I think so. / I hope not.
ellipsis	recoverable clause material	Maya can, but Leo can't.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

the red dress	the red one
complete the form	do so
Will it work?	I think so.
Maya can sing.	Leo can too.

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Using one for an uncountable noun.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Leaving out material whose antecedent is unclear.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Using do so where a natural auxiliary ellipsis is required.

Recognition in context

Choose the form that completes each situation naturally.

A1 · CONTEXT 1

The blue folders are cheaper than the red ___.

OPTIONS ones · one · so · do

A2 · CONTEXT 2

Anyone wishing to appeal must ___ within ten days.

OPTIONS do so · do it so · make so · do one

A3 · CONTEXT 3

Will demand recover? — I think ___.

OPTIONS so · it · one · do

A4 · CONTEXT 4

Is the delay permanent? — I hope ___.

OPTIONS not · no · don't · so not

A5 · CONTEXT 5

Maya had completed the review, but Leo ___.

OPTIONS had not · did not have · not had · had not so

A6 · CONTEXT 6

Ana chose the train and Leo ___ the bus.

OPTIONS the bus · did the bus · one bus · so

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Two connected decisions

Resolve two connected choices within the same context.

B1 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 1

Some supported the motion; others _____. Those who _____ were asked to explain why.

OPTIONS Gap 1: did not / not did / did not so · Gap 2: did so / did it so / made so

B2 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 2

The first proposal was clearer than the second _____, although the committee did not initially think _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: one / so / it one · Gap 2: so / one / do so

B3 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 3

Priya can model the data, and Sam _____ too. If asked to repeat the analysis, both will _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: can / does / can do so it · Gap 2: do so / do one / so

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided text

Maintain the target structure throughout a complete text.

C1 · GUIDED APPLICATION

Two versions were tested: the shorter _____ and the illustrated _____. Most readers preferred the latter, although the editors had expected them _____. When asked whether they would revise it again, the designers said they would _____ if necessary. The publisher hopes _____, because the deadline is close.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

did · do · do not · do one · do so · no · not · not so · not to · one · so

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open text

Supply every form without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT APPLICATION

I chose the larger apartment, not the smaller apartment. -> I chose the larger apartment, not _____. She said she would resign, and she resigned. -> She said she would resign, and she _____. Do you think the plan will work? Yes, I think the plan will work. -> Yes, I think _____. Ana can attend, but I cannot attend. -> Ana can attend, but I _____. One team chose speed; the other team chose accuracy. -> One team chose speed; the other _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

05 · PRACTICE STAGE

Controlled production

Transform the idea without changing its meaning.

E1 · CONTROLLED TASK 1

Avoid repeating report: The first report is clearer than the second report.

_____
_____

E2 · CONTROLLED TASK 2

Avoid repetition: She has submitted the form, but I have not submitted it.

_____
_____

E3 · CONTROLLED TASK 3

Write an original Ellipsis and substitution response for context 3. Include do so online.

_____
_____

E4 · CONTROLLED TASK 4

Write an original Ellipsis and substitution response for context 4. Include leo would submit the form.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative mission

Use the structure in original responses and realistic situations.

F1 · COMMUNICATION TASK 1

Write an original Ellipsis and substitution response for context 1. Include one, has, hope not.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · COMMUNICATION TASK 2

Write an original Ellipsis and substitution response for context 2. Include did so.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · COMMUNICATION TASK 3

Write an original Ellipsis and substitution response for context 3. Include because, referent.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: antecedent.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: ellipsis.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: substitute.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

ones

Use “ones”. Identify exactly which words are repeated.

A2

do so

Use “do so”. Check that the antecedent is unambiguous.

A3

so

Use “so”. Choose ellipsis when the grammar licences an empty position.

A4

not

Use “not”. Choose one, do so, so or not when an explicit substitute improves cohesion.

A5

had not

Use “had not”. Identify exactly which words are repeated.

A6

the bus

Use “the bus”. Check that the antecedent is unambiguous.

Two connected decisions

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

did not / did so

Use “did not”. Identify exactly which words are repeated. Use “did so”. Check that the antecedent is unambiguous.

B2

one / so

Use “one”. Check that the antecedent is unambiguous. Use “so”. Choose ellipsis when the grammar licences an empty position.

B3

can / do so

Use “can”. Choose ellipsis when the grammar licences an empty position. Use “do so”. Choose one, do so, so or not when an explicit substitute improves cohesion.

Guided text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

one

Use “one”. Identify exactly which words are repeated.

C2

one

Use “one”. Check that the antecedent is unambiguous.

C3

not to

Use “not to”. Choose ellipsis when the grammar licences an empty position.

C4

do so

Use “do so”. Choose one, do so, so or not when an explicit substitute improves cohesion.

C5

not

Use “not”. Identify exactly which words are repeated.

Open text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

the smaller one

Use “the smaller one”. Identify exactly which words are repeated.

D2

did

Use “did”. Check that the antecedent is unambiguous.

D3

so

Use “so”. Choose ellipsis when the grammar licences an empty position.

D4

cannot

Use “cannot”. Choose one, do so, so or not when an explicit substitute improves cohesion.

D5

accuracy

Use “accuracy”. Identify exactly which words are repeated.

Controlled production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The first report is clearer than the second one.

Use “The first report is clearer than the second one.”. Identify exactly which words are repeated.

E2

She has submitted the form, but I have not.

Use “She has submitted the form, but I have not.”. Check that the antecedent is unambiguous.

E3

Applicants must register; they can do so online.

Use “Applicants must register; they can do so online.”. Choose ellipsis when the grammar licences an empty position.

E4

Sam told Leo that Leo would submit the form.

Use “Sam told Leo that Leo would submit the form.”. Choose one, do so, so or not when an explicit substitute improves cohesion.

Communicative mission

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

Which draft? The shorter one. Has Mia approved it? She has. Will it change? I hope not.

The model combines accurate Ellipsis and substitution with a clear purpose. Identify exactly which words are repeated.

F2

Some teams adopted the protocol immediately; others did so only after further testing.

The model combines accurate Ellipsis and substitution with a clear purpose. Check that the antecedent is unambiguous.

F3

I repeat “approve the budget” because two earlier actions could be the referent of “do so”.

The model combines accurate Ellipsis and substitution with a clear purpose. Choose ellipsis when the grammar licences an empty position.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____